

Forte 2017 Jonathan Micklos

Business title: Manager, Software Development

Manager: Brian Hanley, bhanley@

Employee portion

What are you most excited about at work?

I am excited about defining and delivering our vision of democratized connected commerce to the world: history's next retail shopping paradigm. I'm excited to do so through the development and alignment of the strengths of members of our team. Delivering our vision requires a team with tremendous ownership and bias-for-action. Empowering that and seeing others deliver/grow gives me immense joy.

When you're at your best, how do you best contribute?

At my best, I rally others to help solve customer needs where my own ownership/bias-for-action/customer-focus can help drive a path forward. Historically, I have reveled in helping to deliver on low-time-availability highly-customer-impacting projects (e.g. free prime for Fire Phone). This continues to shift to working more through others and balancing allowing others to grow while not allowing deliverables to languish.

Are there any growth areas you want help on?

Hire and Develop the Best, Earn Trust, Deliver Results - Historically at Amazon, I have been in organizations with clear top-down expectations and goals. I feel extremely comfortable in such environments. However, my career path requires I over index on being able to build our team to set a bold vision, influence upward, and ultimately deliver results on that vision.

Which Leadership Principles do you most excel at?

Customer Obsession

Leaders start with the customer and work backwards. They work vigorously to earn and keep customer trust. Although leaders pay attention to competitors, they obsess over customers.

Ownership

Leaders are owners. They think long term and don't sacrifice long-term value for short-term results. They act on behalf of the entire company, beyond just their own team. They never say "that's not my job."

Invent and Simplify

Leaders expect and require innovation and invention from their teams and always find ways to simplify. They are externally aware, look for new ideas from everywhere, and are not limited by "not invented here." As we do new things, we accept that we may be misunderstood for long periods of time.

Are Right, A Lot

Leaders are right a lot. They have strong judgment and good instincts. They seek diverse perspectives and work to disconfirm their beliefs.

Learn and Be Curious

Leaders are never done learning and always seek to improve themselves. They are curious about new possibilities and act to explore them.

Insist on the Highest Standards

Leaders have relentlessly high standards - many people may think these standards are unreasonably high. Leaders are continually raising the bar and drive their teams to deliver high quality products, services and processes. Leaders ensure that defects do not get sent down the line and that problems are fixed so they stay fixed.

Think Big

Thinking small is a self-fulfilling prophecy. Leaders create and communicate a bold direction that inspires results. They think differently and look around corners for ways to serve customers.

Bias for Action

Speed matters in business. Many decisions and actions are reversible and do not need extensive study. We value calculated risk taking.

Earn Trust

Leaders listen attentively, speak candidly, and treat others respectfully. They are vocally self-critical, even when doing so is awkward or embarrassing. Leaders do not believe their or their team's body odor smells of perfume. They benchmark themselves and their teams against the best.

Have Backbone; Disagree and Commit

Leaders are obligated to respectfully challenge decisions when they disagree, even when doing so is uncomfortable or exhausting. Leaders have conviction and are tenacious. They do not compromise for the sake of social cohesion. However, once a decision is determined, they commit wholly.

Feedback

You bring a lot of strengths to your work at Amazon. What stands out for me is:

Jonathan has a number of super powers: great raw technical ability. Innovative big ideas & strategic thinking. The ability to conceptualize and align the team's execution to them. Contagious energy and enthusiasm that drives his team forward. Extreme focus on hiring that is paying off. Coaching his employees to be their best. Superb written communication skills.

Here are the super powers your peers provided:

His superpowers are the ability to organize things. He loves getting up to the whiteboard and working through a problem by reaching a common understanding of the facts and leading the group to a logical conclusion.

Jonathan Superpower is EarnTrust, Develop The Best, and BiasForAction. He earned team's trust by providing the right opportunities, visibility and made sure of their success along with program goals. He developed the team from being young to high performance and empowered them to take day-2-day decisions. Demonstrated BiasForAction in prioritizing right features which helped in planning the incremental delivery.

Jonathan does is a phenomenal big thinker. He spent 6 hours brainstorming the strategy for Place Cards which helped give clarity to what we're doing. He also uniquely provides positive feedback to his teammates and peers - I routinely hear him telling others "good job" or "thanks for your help with that".

Jonathan has shown that he really cares for the growth of his employees. He does his best to align an engineers interests with the work available. This is visible from working with his engineers. He has a strong control over process to really drive results. His impact as a manager has shown from the quality of work being delivered.

Jonathan is a problem solver and not one to just accept his fate. Despite being asked to pave the way in many ambiguous areas, sometimes with little precedent, he takes on this task with a positive attitude that I appreciate because I see it reflected in the team. He's also a very organized thinker and has brought much needed discipline.

Jonathan's super power is his ability to quickly grasp complex and nuanced technical challenges, and find opportunities to apply it to drive C7X's initiatives. He does a great job mobilizing the team towards goals and providing leadership opportunities for each team member. Jonathan is passionate about solving complex problems and his enthusiasm is contagious. Thinking big is definitely a strength.

Jonathan's superpower is empowering people around him with his genuine belief in their capabilities. He has always exhibited superior confidence in Bangalore team working with him and his extraordinary

encouragement has lead to the two teams working cohesively without any friction as a singular unit. He has been accommodating enough with late night meetings in his time for Bangalore folks.

Here are the super powers your direct reports provided:

During our meetings when there is ambiguity around a topic , jonathan steps up and brings clarity to the discussion and directs meeting into a correct direction.He analyzes people very well and gives good feedback in one on ones which is helpful for career development.

Jon's drive/enthusiasm helps keep the team excited about the work we do and surely helps keep morale up. Jon represents Amazon in a good light during meetings with 3P-Tiffany. Jon has done a good job in shielding devs from bookstore contacts to allow is to focus on the tasks at hand.

Jonathan does a great job to automate other people/things. He can introduce a clear procedure to make things clearer and easier to perform, which can make the brain do not have to remember the insignificant details. He encourages people to take on more responsibility to play their potential and provide useful feedback to help them grow into a leader.

Jonathan is amazing at giving trust and respect for team members. The level of trust and freedom he gives to team members, especially project leaders, helps to inspire their ownership and leadership.

During meeting/discussion, Jonathan is good at whiteboarding bullet points to help proceed the discussion and summarize. He makes sure the next steps are clearly defined to move forward.

Jonathan is excellent at coming up with ideas on how to make CommerceX's roadmap clearer. This includes coming up with swimlanes for the different project areas we have, creating a template for new projects, and putting out forward-looking plans for the team's structure.

We appreciate people for their strengths, not for the absence of weaknesses. We know that leaders are never done learning and always seek to improve themselves. Below are the growth ideas your co-workers and I provided. We hope you find these ideas useful.

Growth ideas from me:

Couple of ideas for Jonathan to consider: develop a streamlined sprint process that allows his team to deliver predictably and improve their execution over time. Continue to focus on conservative, realistic deadlines targets. Reduce work-in-progress. Continued to focus on meeting personal commitments. Provide more transparency into what the team is and will be working on (regularly updated glide path great.)

Growth ideas from your peers:

Although C7X team is already working on it but little more focus on team's Are right a lot will help in identifying some of the future issues earlier and delivering ahead of time.

Dive deep - encourage Jonathan to be a little more focused on the details of features/capabilities his team owns. While great at thinking big, he sometimes tend to remain at the intellectual level without clearly describing viable application to existing frameworks. Growth in this area will benefit team members to better connect-the-dots from the high-level to feasible next steps.

He has a lot of things going on and it is not always obvious that he is driving them or is on top of them which leads other people to feel the need to manage him. Think he could work on tracking his work better and explaining what he has done to advance the cause of whatever items he owns.

He occasionally doesn't stop running to fully understand what other's are telling him. Sometimes that involves feedback on his team, the project, or just questions about something in development. By stopping more and providing consistent updates, he can get feedback from other's and incorporate their questions into the sprint.

Simplification is something I'd like to see Jonathan grow to the next level. 1) Communications: focus on simplifying his messaging and giving his audience only what they need and in the most digestable way possible. 2) Process: simplifying his team's work mental model to create order but not drag that would impact speed.

Growth ideas from your direct reports:

I think Jonathan's ideas on how to make the CommerceX team's future clearer are great, but I would like to see more concrete actions to execute on them. There are a lot of good ideas, but not enough putting down our foot and saying "let's do this now."

I'd also like to see more support from Jonathan to reduce processes/reports for the team to bias more on action and move faster. I'd like to see more help from Jonathan on project resources and hiring. I'd like to see Jonathan provides more technical vision to the team.

If Jonathan could communicate more frequently with team members to get status updates and share team road maps and new initiatives, I will better understand how my work adapts to the bigger picture that can make me creative and feel more comfortable in the team to grow.

Thank you!

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